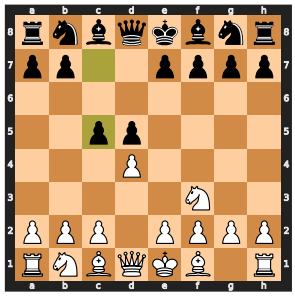
Game 2



Queen's Gambit Declined

Rubinstein – Capablanca

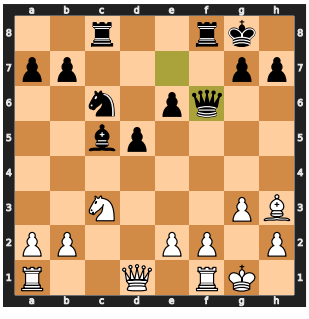
San Sebastian 1911

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 exd5

5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.g3 ♗e6 7.♗g2 ♗e7 8.0–0 ♖c8

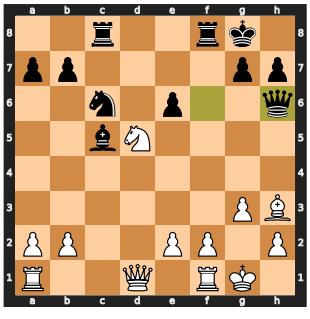
6...♗e6 avoiding the beaten track	**2**
8...♖c8 a change with poor success	**2**
14.♗xf6 Rubinstein's combination begins	**2**
16.♔g2! the move Black had not considered	**2**
30...a6 a lost chance to draw	**3**
38.♗d5 a blunder that goes unpunished	**3**

after 14...♕xf6



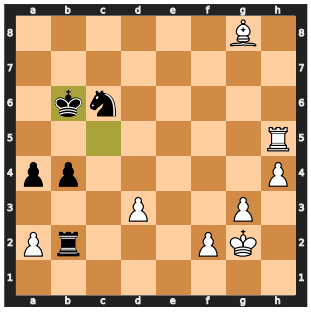
15.♘xd5!

after 15...♕h6



16.♔g2!

after 37...♔b6



38.♗d5

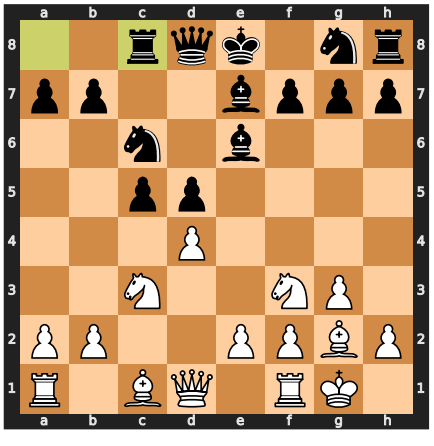
Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.g3 ♗e6

6...♘f6 is the normal move in this variation. White's development was first introduced by Schlechter and elaborated later on by Rubinstein. It aims at the isolation of Black's d-pawn, against which the White pieces are gradually concentrated. In making the text move I was trying to avoid the beaten track. Being a developing move there should be no objection to it in the way of general principles, except that the Knights ought to come out before the Bishops.

7.♗g2 ♗e7 8.0–0 ♖c8

In pursuance of the idea of changing the normal course of this variation, but with very poor success. The move in theory ought to be unsound, since Black's king's knight is yet undeveloped. I had not yet learned of the attack founded on ♘g5 and the exchange of the Bishop on e6. Either 8...♘f6 or 8...h6, to prevent either ♗ or ♘g5, was right.

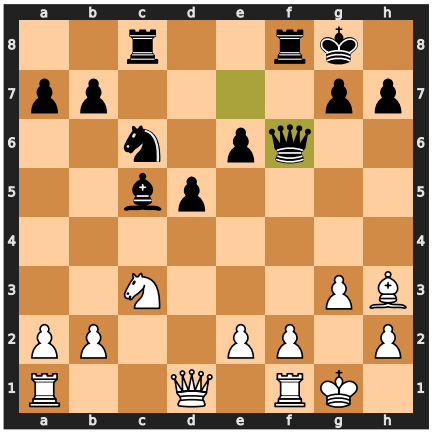


9.dxc5 ♗xc5 10.♘g5 ♘f6 11.♘xe6 fxe6 12.♗h3 ♕e7 13.♗g5 0–0

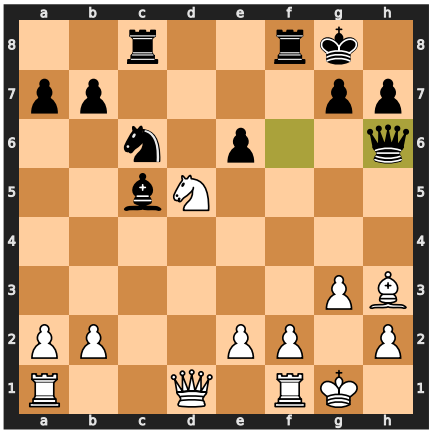
This is a mistake. The right move was 13...♖d8 in order to get the Rook away from the line of the Bishop on h3 and at the same time to support the d-pawn. Incidentally it shows that White failed to take proper advantage of Black's weak opening moves. Against the text move White makes a very fine combination which I had seen, but which I thought could be defeated.

14.♗xf6 ♕xf6

I considered 14...gxf6, which it seemed would give me a playable game, but I thought White's combination unsound and therefore let him play it, to my lasting regret.



15.♘xd5! ♕h6



16.♔g2!

This is the move which I had not considered. I thought that Rubinstein would have to play 16.♗g2, when I had in mind the following winning combination: 16.♗g2 ♘e5! 17.♘f4 (if 17.♖c1 ♕xc1!! 18.♕xc1 ♗xf2+ wins), 17...♘g4 18.h3 (if 18.♘h3 ♗xf2+ wins the exchange), 18...♘xf2 19.♖xf2 ♗xf2+ 20.♔xf2 g5, and Black should win. It is curious that this combination has been overlooked. It has been taken for granted that I did not see the 17th move 17.♕c1.

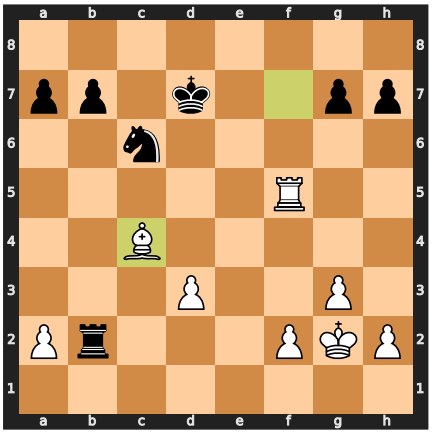
16...♖cd8

After White's last move there was nothing for me to do but submit to the inevitable.

17.♕c1! exd5 18.♕xc5 ♕d2 19.♕b5 ♘d4 20.♕d3 ♕xd3 21.exd3 ♖fe8 22.♗g4

This gives Black a chance. He should have played 22.♖fe1. If then 22...♘c2 23.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 24.♖c1 ♖e2 25.♔f1 25...♘d4 (if 25...♖d2 26.♗e6+ ♔f8 27.♗xd5 would win); 26.♖c8+ ♔f7 27.♖c7+ ♖e7 28.♖c5 wins.

22...♖d6 23.♖fe1 ♖xe1 24.♖xe1 ♖b6 25.♖e5 ♖xb2 26.♖xd5 ♘c6 27.♗e6+ ♔f8 28.♖f5+ ♔e8 29.♗f7+ ♔d7 30.♗c4

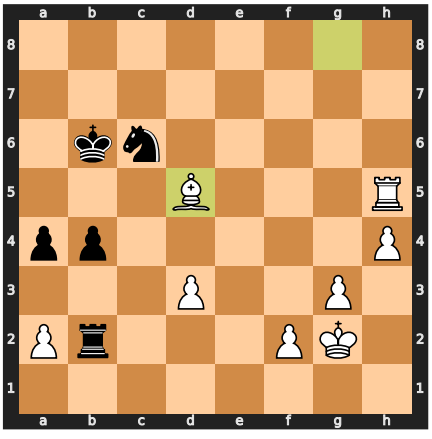


30...a6

A bad move, which gives away any legitimate chance Black had to draw. It loses a very important move. In fact, as the course of the game will show, it loses several moves. The proper way was to play 30...♔d6. If then 31.♖b5 ♖xb5 32.♗xb5 ♘d4, followed by ...b5; and White would have an exceedingly difficult game to draw on account of the dominating position of the Knight on d4 in conjunction with the extra Pawn on the Queen's side and the awkward position of White's King. (See how this is so.)

31.♖f7+ ♔d6 32.♖xg7 b5 33.♗g8 a5 34.♖xh7 a4 35.h4 b4 36.♖h6+ ♔c5 37.♖h5+ ♔b6 38.♗d5

With these last three moves White again gives Black a chance. Even before the last move 38.♗c4 would have won with comparative ease, but the text move is a downright blunder, of which, fortunately for him, Black does not avail himself.



38...b3

38...♖xa2 would make it practically impossible for White to win, if he can win at all. White's best continuation then would have been: 39.♗c4 ♖c2 40.♖b5+ ♔c7 41.♗g8 a3 42.h5 a2 43.♗xa2 ♖xa2, and if there is a win it is very difficult to find it, as against 44.h6 ♖a3! offers excellent chances for a draw.

39.axb3 a3 40.♗xc6 ♖xb3

If 40...a2 41.♖b5+ ♔a6 42.♖b8.

41.♗d5 a2 42.♖h6+
Resigns.

As an end game, this is rather a sad exhibition for two masters. The redeeming feature of the game is Rubinstein's fine combination in the middle game, beginning with 14.♗xf6.